

BASIC SIGHT-SINGING AND EAR TRAINING FOR CHURCH SINGERS

UNIT 9.1 – FORMS AND STRUCTURES

CATEGORIES OF MELODIES IN ORTHODOX CHANT —

CANONS



THE FORM AND STRUCTURE OF CANON MELODIES

In previous units we examined the **structured patterns** and the **melodic phrases** that define the respective Eight Tones for stichera and troparia. Many of those melodies are well known to singers in Orthodox churches of that follow the Slavic tradition. In this unit we examine a category of melodies that tend to be somewhat less familiar—the **canon** (also spelled **kanon**).

As a liturgical form, the canon is fairly complex: it consists of 9 **odes**, each of which is patterned on a Biblical **canticle**—a poetic prayer, likely sung rather than spoken. Eight of these canticles are taken from the Old Testament—respectively attributed to Miriam (1), Moses (2), Hannah (3), Habakkuk (4), Isaiah (5), Jonah (6), and the Three Youths (7 and 8); the 9th Ode is the Canticle of the Most Holy Theotokos, found in Luke 1:46-56. In practice, Ode 2 is only used in canons during Great Lent. Thus, a typical canon has only 8 odes.

Each ode begins with an initial stanza called an **heirmos** (which literally means “link”), and is followed by two, three or more stanzas (also called “troparia”). In the original Greek, these troparia matched the heirmos in terms of the number of phrases and syllables, making it possible to sing the troparia to the melody of the heirmos. But in Slavic practice, only the heirmos is sung.

CANON MELODIES (CONT'D)

Each Tone in the Eight-Tone scheme of hymnography has its own melodies for the **heirmoi** (plural of **heirmos**) of canons. To examine each Tone in detail, we would have to look at 8 different melodies—each of the odes—and we would see how the ingenious anonymous composers of these melodies created variants to accommodate the multitude of texts.

For the purposes of our course, we will be looking at just one representative sample per Tone, selected from a rather large assortment of possibilities.

Canons are prescribed to be sung at Matins, following the reading of the Matins Gospel. Like Resurrectional Stichera, Troparia and Kontakia, the Resurrectional Canons rotate with the cycle of Eight Tones. Canons also figure prominently in the services of Great Lent (the main liturgical book used during Lent, the **Lenten Triodion**, derives its name from the numerous **three-ode canons** it contains).

Canon melodies are also used for the **Festal Hymns to the Theotokos** (*zadostoiniki*), which replace “It is truly meet” during Holy Week, the 40 days of Pascha, and the 12 major feasts.

STUDY NOTES FOR THE SLIDES THAT FOLLOW

By now you should be familiar with the routine approach one uses to get acquainted with a new and unfamiliar melody.

For each sample canon Tone presented in the following slides:

1. Read the Analysis and observe and identify the “Things to notice” for each sample heirmos that follows. Print out each slide.
2. Write in the Kodály rhythmic syllables if need be.
3. Identify the key and the starting note. Write in the SOL-FA syllables.
4. While the macrostructure for each Tone has been provided, identify the microstructure and all motives that repeat. Locate and mark triple groupings in the text.
5. Practice sight-singing each melody and record, using flipgrid.

CANON TONE 1 (COMMON CHANT) - ANALYSIS

Canon Tone 1 is used for such well-known occasions as Pascha, the Nativity of Christ, and the Dormition of the Theotokos (August 15). There are other variants of Canon Tone 1 in use, such as the Russian “Greek” Chant, which is somewhat more melodic than Common Tone 1.

Things to notice:

1. Although the key signature has one sharp, suggesting G Major, Phrase 3, which also happens to be the Final Phrase, comes to rest on D Major.

HINT: Try singing with DO=G and then with DO=D. Which DO gives you a greater sense of having “arrived” at home base (which is how we defined the **tonic** back in Units 1 and 2)?

2. When a piece of music, even a very short one, starts in one key and ends in another one, we call this a **modulation**. Canon Tone 1 is an example of this.

CANON TONE 1 (COMMON CHANT)

December 25: Nativity of the Lord

Canon I • TONE ONE

Heirmos 1

1 2

Christ is born; glo - ri - fy Him. Christ comes from heav - en; go to

3 1a

meet Him. Christ is on earth; be ex - alt - ed. Sing to the Lord,

2 3

all the earth, and praise Him in glad-ness, O peo - ple, for

He has been glo - ri - fied.

CANON TONE 2 (LESSER ZNAMENNY CHANT) – ANALYSIS

Canon Tone 2 figures prominently in the Bridegroom Matins services of Holy Week. It is also appointed for the Canon for the Nativity of the Theotokos (September 8) and Theophany (January 6). There is also a “Common Chant” version for Canon Tone 2, which is less melodic than the Lesser Znamenny.

Things to notice:

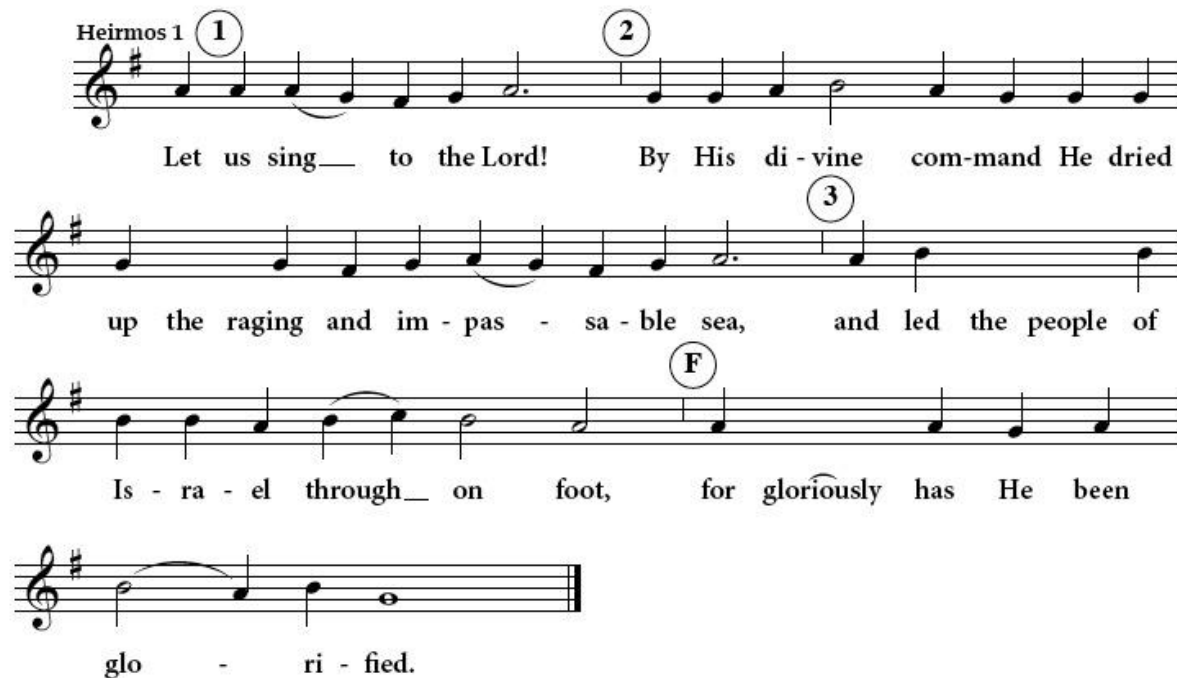
1. The key signature (one sharp) suggests G as the tonic.
2. The melody, however, spends a lot of time on RE=A, before finally settling on G=DO in the final phrase.
3. In this example, Phrase 1 starts on the reciting tone, A. But sometimes, depending on the text, it has a “beginning” which is the same as Phrase 2.
4. When the text requires it, Phrase 3 can be repeated twice in a row.
5. If the text requires, there is also a Phrase 4 (not shown here).
6. As the above discussion shows, the nature and order of phrases is flexible.

CANON TONE 2 (LESSER ZNAMENNY CHANT)

Great and Holy Monday

Three-Ode Canon • TONE TWO

Heirmos 1



Let us sing to the Lord! By His di-vine com-mand He dried
up the raging and im-pas-sa-ble sea, and led the people of
Is-ra-el through on foot, for gloriously has He been
glo-ri-fied.

CANON TONE 3 - (ABBR. KIEVAN CHANT) - ANALYSIS

Canon Tone 3 is appointed for the feast of the Meeting of the Lord (February 2). While in most Tones, the canon melodies are distinct from stichera or troparia melodies, Tone 3 is an exception: the Abbreviated Kievan Chant melody is essentially identical to the Kievan Chant **sticheron** Tone. Another version of the canon Tone—the Abbreviated “Greek” Chant—is identical to the **troparion** Tone.

Things to notice:

1. Canon Tone 3 is written in the key of G (one sharp in the key signature), but the melody begins on A (RE), and ends, not on the tonic G=DO, but on F#, which is TI; the tonic G is “felt” rather than “heard,” since the melody barely touches it.
2. For this reason, when sung without harmony, the melody may seem to be “unstable.”
3. Just like sticheron Tone 3, there are two phrases (1, 2), which alternate, and then a Final Phrase in conclusion.

CANON TONE 3 (ABBR. KIEVAN CHANT) (p. 1)

February 2: The Meeting of the Lord

Canon • TONE THREE

Heirmos 9 1



In the shad - ow and the let - ter of the Law, let us the

1



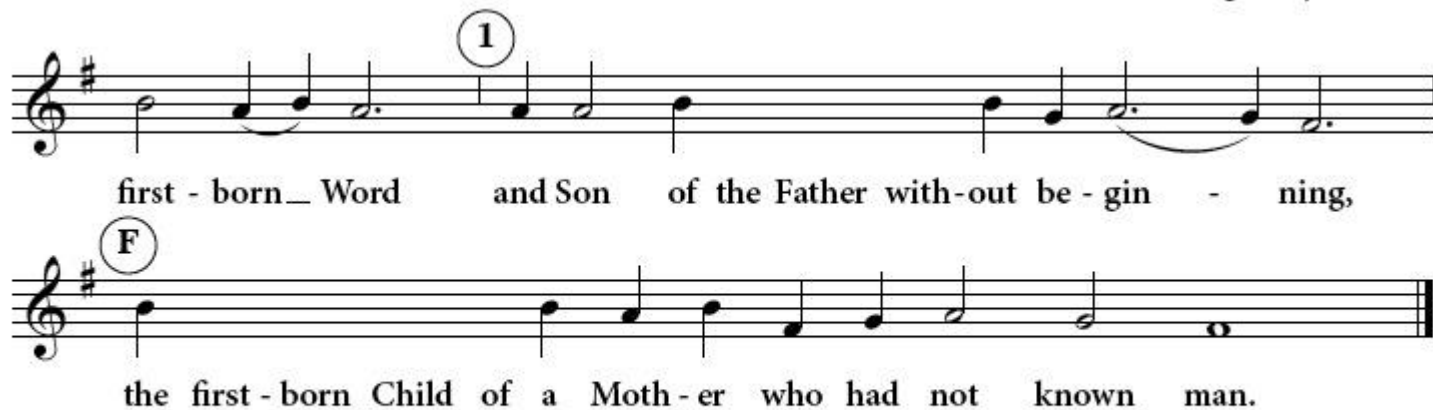
faith-ful dis-cern a fig - ure: ev - ery male child that o - pens the

2



womb shall be sanc - ti - fied to God. There - fore do we magni - fy the

CANON TONE 3 (ABBR. KIEVAN CHANT) (p. 2)



first - born_ Word and Son of the Father with-out be - gin - ning,

the first - born Child of a Moth - er who had not known man.

CANON TONE 4 (ABBR. KIEVAN CHANT) – ANALYSIS

Canon Tone 4 is used for the General Canon to the Theotokos, “I will open my mouth,” which is also used, with textual variants, for the feasts of the Entrance of the Theotokos, the Annunciation, and the Dormition (2nd Canon). In addition, it is used for the Canons of Palm Sunday, Transfiguration, and the 2nd Canon of Pentecost. In addition to the Abbreviated Kievan Chant version, there is another, more melodic and complex melody that was preserved in the chant books of certain monasteries, such as the Solovetsk Monastery.

Things to notice:

1. The key signature — one sharp, suggests G Major (G=DO); but just as in the case of Tone 3, the melody begins on A=RE, hardly touches the tonic G, and ends on F#=TI.
2. There are two phrases (1, 2), which alternate, followed by a Final Phrase.

CANON TONE 4 - (ABBR. KIEVAN CHANT)

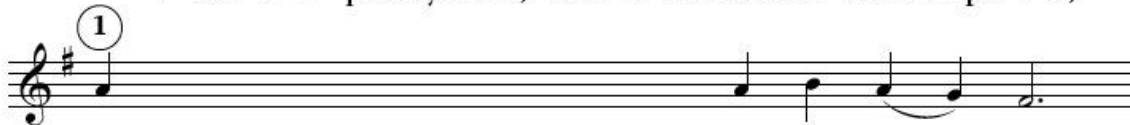
General Canon to the Theotokos

TONE FOUR

Heimos 1



I will o - pen my mouth, and it will be filled with the Spir - it,



and I will pour forth my words to the Queen and Moth - er.



I will be seen ra - di - ant - ly keep-ing feast and will joy - ful - ly



praise her won - ders.

CANON TONE 5 (LESSER ZNAMENNY CHANT) - ANALYSIS

Canon Tone 5 is appointed for the feast of the Ascension. Though called “Lesser Znamenny,” this melody bears some resemblance to sticheron and troparion Tone 5. As in the case of Tone 2, there is also a “Common Chant” version for Canon Tone 5, which is less melodic than the Lesser Znamenny.

Things to notice:

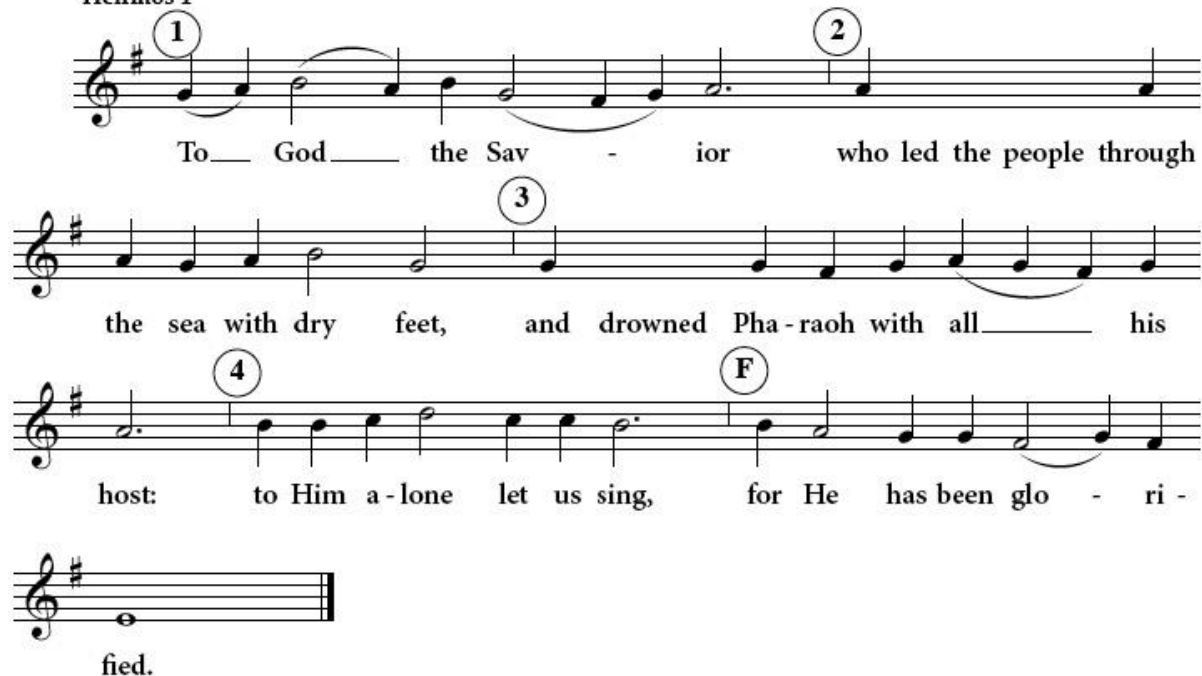
1. The key signature — one sharp, suggests G Major or E Minor.
2. The first three phrases sound like they are in a major key, but the Final Phrase descends and ends on E=LA, suggesting the same kind of **dual tonic** that we observed in several of the stichera Tones (see Unit 7.1).
3. There are several variants of the various phrases throughout the Canon, made flexible by the sharing of the beginnings and endings of the phrases; Phrase 4 is sometimes used and sometimes omitted.

CANON TONE 5 - (LESSER ZNAMENNY CHANT)

Ascension

Canon I • TONE FIVE

Heirmos 1



1 2

To God the Sav - ior who led the people through

3

the sea with dry feet, and drowned Pha-raoh with all his

4 F

host: to Him a-lone let us sing, for He has been glo - ri -

fied.

CANON TONE 6 (COMMON CHANT AND LESSER ZNAMENNY CHANTS) – ANALYSIS

Canon Tone 6 is used during Great Lent (the Great Canon of St. Andrew of Crete) and during Holy Week (the Canons of Holy Thursday, Friday, and Saturday—also sung at the Nocturns service before Paschal Matins). The Resurrectional Canon in Tone 6 is also appointed for the Memorial Service (Panikhida) and the Burial Service.

1. The key signature — one sharp, indicates G Major or E Minor; the presence of the accidental D#=SI suggests that the key is E Minor.
2. The melodic similarities between the two versions show that what is known as “Common Chant” developed from Znamenny Chant, which is much older in its origins.

CANON TONE 6 - (COMMON CHANT)

Resurrectional Octoechos

CANON • Tone 6

Heirmos 1

1 2

When Israel passed on foot o - ver the sea as if it were

3 4

dry land, and beheld their pursu - er Pha - raoh_

4

drown - ing in the sea, they_ cried a - loud un - to God:_

F

"Let us sing a song of vic - - - to - ry!"

CANON TONE 6 - (LESSER ZNAMENNY CHANT)

Resurrectional Octoechos

CANON • Tone 6

Heirmos 1

1

2

When Israel passed on foot o - ver_ the sea as if it were

3

dry_ land, and be - held their pursuer, Pha - raoh

2

3

drown-ing in the_ sea, they cried a - loud_ un - to God:

F

"Let us sing a song of vic - - - to - ry!"

CANON TONE 7 (KIEVAN CHANT) - ANALYSIS

Canon Tone 7 is appointed for the 1st Canon of Pentecost.

Things to notice:

1. The key signature is one flat, which suggests F Major.
2. The two phrases (1,2) alternate, after which there is a Final Phrase.
3. Phrases 1 and 2 are clearly in F Major, but the Final Phrase ends on G=RE, which indicates a **dual tonic**.

CANON TONE 7 (KIEVAN CHANT)

Holy Pentecost

Canon I • TONE SEVEN

Heirmos 3

Thoudidst say to Thy dis - ci - ples, O Christ: "Re-main in Je - ru - sa -

lem until you are clothed with pow - er from on high. And I will send

you an - oth - er Com - for - ter, like un - to me: He is my Spir - it, and the

Spir - it of my Fa - ther; you shall be es - tab - lished in__ Him."

CANON TONE 8 (RUSSIAN “GREEK” CHANT) - ANALYSIS

Canon Tone 8 is appointed for the feast of the Elevation of the Cross.

Things to notice:

1. The key signature—one sharp, suggests G Major.
2. There are two phrases (1, 2), which alternate, followed in the end by a Final Phrase.
3. Phrase 1 begins on the leading tone—F#=TI—and ends on DO.
4. Phrase 2 begins on DO and ends on RE
5. The Final Phrase ends on DO.

CANON TONE 8 - (RUSSIAN "GREEK" CHANT)

Elevation of the Cross

Canon • TONE EIGHT

Heirmos 9

1 2

You are a mystical Paradise, O The - o - to - kos, who, though

1

un - tilled, have brought forth— Christ; through Him the lifebearing wood

2

of the Cross was plant - ed on earth. Now at its El - e - va - tion, //

F

as we bow in wor - ship be - fore it, we mag - ni - fy you.

There are no separate Form Analysis Exercises for this Unit.

- Please review the instructions on Slide 4 above.
- Print out and mark up the slides of the Canon Tones.
- Scan or photograph your marked up copies and send them to OCATeacher1@oca.org
- Practice and record your singing of the Canon Tones.

